

INFECTIOUS DISEASE EPIDEMIOLOGIST REPORT (October 2020)

Questions:

1. Does hosting as live event as described above present a greater risk to attendees, as opposed to hosting a virtual event?
2. If the decision is made to host a live event, what must be done to assure that the attendees are not at a greater risk of infection than “normal” day-to-day risk.

The following report outlines special considerations and challenges in hosting a live nine-day event in April 2021. The event will occur in a hotel and will host approximately 175 participants. The majority of attendees will travel to New York City from throughout the United States and Canada. Please note: throughout the document, I often use COVID-19 in lieu of SARS-COV-2 (the virus that causes COVID-19).

Challenges:

- 1) Use of public transportation and failure to completely follow all safety and health guidelines as noted below present the greatest challenges in hosting as live event.
- 2) Given the size of the event, one infected person can create a “super-spreader” event given the length of the event.
- 3) The demographics of the General Service Conference attendees have a higher risk of mortality if they develop COVID-19. The median age (59) and likely co-morbid conditions of prospective attendees (hypertension, diabetes, history of smoking) leads me to believe that the mortality rate will be high for attendees that develop COVID-19.

Actions/Procedures

If hosting a live event as described, the following protocol should be followed:

Pre-Conference

Testing. Every attendee will test for COVID-19 within 7 days of departure to the GSC. In the window between testing and departure for the event, attendees will mask at all times outside their home. In addition, they will ensure physical distancing (greater than

6') to the greatest extent possible during the week prior to the Conference irrespective of the rate of COVID-19 in their home community, vaccine status, or prior COVID-19 infection. Attendees will report test results to Conference planners prior to entry into the event. In order to ensure access to testing, attendees should provide location & date of test acquisition, and time & date of anticipated test results. by February 28th, 2021.

Transportation. If feasible, attendees should travel to the Conference via personal transportation. Use of public transportation (including air travel) increases the risk of infection. It is acknowledged that personal transportation for many attendees is impractical (e.g. those from the west coast) or not feasible (e.g., attendees from Hawaii).

During Conference

Masks: Attendees must be masked at all times, except during meals and when in personal hotel room. Attendees should wear medical masks (loops around the ears) and these should cover the nose, mouth, and chin.

Meals:

- Meals must be monitored:
 - No eating out in restaurants
 - Everyone eats at the same time
 - No talking during meals
 - Meal time shortened (i.e., 15 minutes per meal)
 - Hand hygiene must be practiced prior to taking off masks (at meal start), and prior to putting mask back on.
- Meals must be organized wherein attendees are at least 6 feet apart

Meetings:

- Social distance guidelines followed during all meetings – please sit at least 6' apart. Please 'elbow bump' or 'fist bump' rather than hug as a form of greeting.
- Wear masks at all times.
- Microphone use – Special accommodations for microphone use will take into account that we can (occasionally) transmit COVID-19 beyond 6 feet if we are not wearing masks. Accordingly, attendees need to be at least 12 feet from the microphone. Hand hygiene should be implemented as well.

Summary

As of this writing, we will likely face COVID-19 related challenges throughout 2021. These challenges put conference attendees at potential risk. If we act with unity, in a manner that places the common welfare first, we will minimize and protect our fellow members.

INDUSTRY STANDARDS

Talley Management Group (TMG) is active with all the event industry's associations to help understand the short, medium, and long-term impacts on events of all types. This involves collaboration with healthcare professionals and government officials at all levels. We are also involved in research looking at stakeholder engagement and decisions to fund travel and attendance. We have access to "pulse data" from across the industry that is monitoring event owner's intentions every two weeks. There is great variability around the globe based on the impact and control of the virus.

As we know, the US remains challenged with 30-40,000 new cases per day and the expectation for a difficult fall and winter. That will have further impact on planning for the return of live events. At this point and before any potential spikes in the fall the consensus is that the earliest event owners will attempt large scale events is the end of the second quarter, 2021.

Event owners have a responsibility for the health and safety of their attendees. Many corporations will not allow employees to travel at all until the risk of infection is minimal and/or there is an effective and widespread distribution of a vaccine which is not expected until mid-2021 at the earliest.

Even when events start back up there will be added costs related to attendee health and safety that really have not been fully fleshed out. But we know more space would be needed for any event given social distancing which increases rent and production costs. Event owners will be evaluating the options and while it may be possible to do a live event in these times – should we? Is the attempt to resume events putting more people at risk: attendees, staff, venue, and hotel staff, etc.

What do we know about our audience and their preferences? What does that tell us about their readiness to attend? That decision is based on their feelings regarding safety over the entire journey. It is not just a question of the event venue, but about the entire travel experience – every point of potential contact.

CDC GUIDING PRINCIPLES REGARDING GATHERINGS (CDC Website, July 2020)

A gathering refers to a planned or spontaneous event, indoors or outdoors, with a small number of people participating or a large number of people in attendance such as a community event or gathering, concert, festival, conference, parade, wedding, or sporting event.

The *more people* an individual interacts with at a gathering and the longer that interaction lasts, the higher the potential risk of becoming infected with COVID-19 and COVID-19 spreading.

The *higher the level of community transmission* in the area that the gathering is being held, the higher the risk of COVID-19 spreading during a gathering.

The risk of COVID-19 spreading at events and gatherings increases as follows:

Lowest risk: Virtual-only activities, events, and gatherings.

More risk: Smaller outdoor and in-person gatherings in which individuals from different households remain spaced at least 6 feet apart, wear masks, do not share objects, and come from the same local area (e.g., community, town, city, or county).

Higher risk: Medium-sized in-person gatherings that are adapted to allow individuals to remain spaced at least 6 feet apart and with attendees coming from outside the local area.

Highest risk: Large in-person gatherings where it is difficult for individuals to remain spaced at least 6 feet apart and attendees travel from outside the local area.

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Guiding Principles to Keep in Mind

A gathering refers to a planned or spontaneous event, indoors or outdoors, with a small number of people participating, or a large number of people in attendance. Examples of gatherings, small or large, include a community event, concert, festival, conference, parade, wedding, or sporting event.

- The more people an individual interacts with at a gathering and the longer that interaction lasts, the higher the individual's potential risk of becoming infected with COVID-19 and then spreading COVID-19 to others.
- The [higher the level of community transmission](#) in the area where the gathering is held, the higher the risk of COVID-19 spreading at the gathering.
- The size (attendance) of an event or gathering should be determined based on state, local, territorial, or tribal safety laws and regulations.

The risk of COVID-19 spreading at events and gatherings increases as follows:

- **Lowest risk:** Virtual-only activities, events, and gatherings.
- **More risk:** Smaller outdoor gatherings in which individuals from different households remain spaced at least 6 feet apart, wear cloth face coverings, do not share objects, and come from the same local area (e.g., a community, town, city, or county).
- **Higher risk:** Medium-sized in-person gatherings that are organized/laid out to allow individuals to remain spaced at least 6 feet apart, some wear cloth face coverings and come from outside the local area (e.g., a community, town, city, or county).
- **Highest risk:** Large in-person gatherings where it is difficult for individuals to remain spaced at least 6 feet apart, do not wear cloth face coverings and travel from outside the local area.



cdc.gov/coronavirus

New York State COVID-19 Social Distancing Guidelines as of September 30, 2020

- Gathering Restrictions Outdoors: **Groups
of 50 or less**
- Gathering Restrictions Indoors:
25% Capacity or less

As of August 11, 2020: New York City Travel Restrictions

If you're traveling into New York City, you will likely encounter a [quarantine checkpoint](#). The city is placing these checkpoints at key entry points like bridges and tunnels to remind land travelers of the state quarantine. Penn Station and the Port Authority Bus Terminal are two checkpoint locations.

While air travelers must submit their declaration form at the airport, it's the responsibility of land travelers to self-report their stay details. These checkpoints ensure travelers do not slip through the cracks by not submitting a form.

New York City is partnering with local hotels, rental car agencies, bus and train terminals to provide easy online access to the state's traveler health form. Completing the form online before you arrive can reduce your wait time at these checkpoints.

One-fifth of New York City's new cases come from out-of-state travelers. Local [Test & Trace Corps](#) authorities will also check up on those in quarantine to verify they stay in place while in the city. New York law enforcement is checking up on income travelers throughout the state as well for quarantine compliance.

There is a maximum fine of \$10,000 if you violate the quarantine and cause potential harm to another person. Those who fly into New York State are subject to the same hefty fine for flagrant quarantine violations.

CORONAVIRUS DISEASE (COVID-19)

You may have come into contact with the virus that causes COVID-19

MANDATORY QUARANTINE

The Government of Canada has put in place emergency measures to slow the introduction and spread of COVID-19 in Canada. You **MUST QUARANTINE for 14 days, provide contact information and monitor yourself for symptoms** subject to the *Minimizing the Risk of Exposure to COVID-19 in Canada Order (Mandatory Isolation) No. 3*.

Your compliance with this Order is subject to verification and enforcement.

Those in violation may face transfer to a quarantine facility as well as fines and/or imprisonment.

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| ✓ Ensure you have a suitable place of quarantine that has the necessities of life. | ✗ Avoid contact with others while in transit: |
| ✓ Go directly to your place of quarantine without delay and stay there for 14 days from the date you arrived in Canada. | ✓ Remain in the vehicle as much as possible; |
| ✓ You <u>must</u> wear a suitable non-medical mask or face covering while in transit. | ✓ If you need gas, pay at the pump; |
| ✓ Practise physical distancing at all times. | ✓ If you need food, use a drive through; |
| ✓ Use private transportation such as a private vehicle to reach your place of quarantine, if possible. | ✓ If you need to use a rest area, put on your mask and be mindful of physical distancing and good hygiene practices. |

SOME PROVINCES AND TERRITORIES HAVE ADDITIONAL TRAVEL RESTRICTIONS

(For example, no non-essential travel into the province, limited access to certain regions within the province, etc.).

Please refer to the list of provincial and territorial websites on the back of this handout for more information.

Note that you may also be contacted by provincial/territorial authorities throughout your 14-day quarantine and, if federal and provincial/territorial guidelines differ, you should follow the most precautionary and stringent requirements.

Canadian Travel Restrictions

- The Government of Canada has restricted non-essential travel of foreign nationals across its border. Foreign nationals wishing to enter Canada by air for optional, non-essential or discretionary purposes will not be permitted. Non-essential travel includes travelling for purposes such as tourism, sightseeing, recreation, entertainment, social visits and religious functions.